

Wake up CALL

By Elora Sen

Among the 42 ministers in the West Bengal government is Pratim Chatterjee who is the oddly titled Minister for Fire and Emergency Services. One of his prime duties is to ensure that the state does not burn. But he sits in Kolkata where acceptance of tragedy and general apathy far outweigh any constructive outcry. So, even after a disaster like the one that engulfed Nandaram Market in January 2008, Stephen Court was something that was waiting to happen. The 100-hour fight with the Nandaram blaze had almost disappeared from public memory till disaster struck the street where Kolkata goes to party. Stephen Court, a landmark building on Park Street, took on a hellish look on the afternoon of March 23. Till last Monday, 43 people had died and no one's saying that this inferno would be the last.

Kolkata is a city full of tinderboxes, many of which are heritage structures that have been changed and modified to suit the needs of those who reside or do business in them, and pay little heed to the laws of the land. As usual, there is now a frenzied effort at damage control. The state police, the Kolkata Municipal Corporation and the fire services met on March 26 to draw up a list of 10 fire-prone residential and commercial premises and three slums in central Kolkata and have started inspecting them. Amazingly enough, these premises were supposed to be under the scanner after the Nandaram Market fire, but it had taken a Stephen Court to happen for the authorities to shrug off their inaction. Most of these buildings have entrances through

The Stephen Court fire is the latest symptom of the mess that Kolkata, a city full of tinderboxes, continues to be



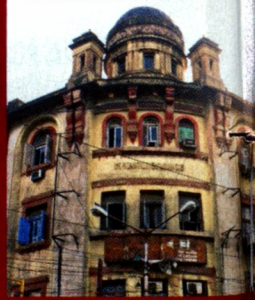
GROUND ZERO

MEHTA BUILDING



■ Kolkata's wholesale pharmaceutical business hub had seen a major fire in 2008. But nothing has really changed in the building; cramped with small offices, it is a maze of narrow corridors with wires hanging everywhere.

MERCANTILE BUILDING



which a fire engine cannot enter easily, maze-like interiors, wooden staircases and ancient lifts. Electrical wires hanging dangerously overhead and the storage of highly inflammable articles add to the hazards. Moreover, proper fire-fighting equipment like sprinklers is also not available.

Most structures along Park Street

are over 100 years old and down the years considerable internal changes have been made, flouting building norms. In most restaurants, the kitchens are potential fire hazards and the civic authorities have failed to take necessary preventive measures. Even a posh address like the Park Hotel has a narrow entranceway